World Cup 2026 Travel Companion App

Hackathon Project Brief — GDG Newport Beach x RocketRide x GMI Cloud

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Purpose/Problem

Millions of international fans will travel to the US for the 2026 FIFA World Cup — many for the first time. They need more than just match tickets; they need to know where to eat, what to do, how to get around, and how to find the hidden gems that locals love.

This app is a stadium-first travel guide powered by AI. The core idea is simple: every World Cup stadium is a pin on a map. Tap a pin, get everything you need to know about that city — matches, neighborhoods, food, nightlife, and a chat agent that can dig into Reddit forums and local sources to answer any specific question a traveler might have.

The target user is an international fan who has tickets to one or more matches and wants to make the most of their trip without spending hours researching across 10 different sites.

Important Links

- Excalidraw Diagram

MVP Definition

Three core features that must work end-to-end for a successful hackathon demo. Everything else is a stretch goal.

1. **1. Feature 1 — Interactive Stadium Map**

A full-screen map (Google Maps) with a pin for each of the 16 World Cup 2026 stadiums across the US, Canada, and Mexico. Tapping a pin navigates the user to that stadium's dedicated page. This is the app's front door and must feel polished — clean pins, a brief tooltip on hover, and a smooth transition to the stadium page.

Why this matters:

- International fans think in terms of stadiums and cities, not a list of links
- The map creates an immediate wow moment in the demo
- It anchors every other feature — everything branches from a stadium

2. **2. Feature 2 — Stadium City Page**

Each stadium gets its own page with three sections stacked vertically:

- Hero banner — a full-width image of the stadium with its name, city, and capacity overlaid
- Match schedule — a card list of all games being played at that stadium (date, teams, group/round)
- City overview — a short paragraph about the city plus key logistics (nearest airport, time zone, language tips)
- Spots sidebar — five category tabs (Food, Coffee, Shopping, Nightlife, Activities), each showing the 5 most popular spots pulled from the Google Maps Places API, sorted by review rating

The sidebar is pre-populated with real data. No AI inference needed here — just a clean API call to Google Maps on page load.

3. **3. Feature 3 — AI Travel Chat Agent**

A chat interface embedded on each stadium page (and accessible globally). The agent can answer any travel question about the city — from generic requests like 'best brunch spot' to highly specific ones like 'where do locals actually go for coffee that isn't touristy?'

How it works under the hood:

- Generic requests (e.g. 'best pizza near MetLife') — agent calls Google Maps Places API and surfaces top-rated results with a brief summary
- Specific or qualitative requests (e.g. 'most unique hidden gem bar') — agent triggers an Exa.ai search that scrapes relevant city subreddits (r/nyc, r/AskNYC, r/worldcup, etc.) and the official FIFA site, then synthesizes the results into a recommendation with source attribution

- The agent knows which city it is in context of, so users do not need to specify 'in New York' if they are already on the MetLife page

This is the feature that wins the demo. The ability to go from a polished map pin to a hyper-specific, Reddit-backed local recommendation in under 30 seconds is the core value proposition.

User Flow

Step-by-step walk-through:

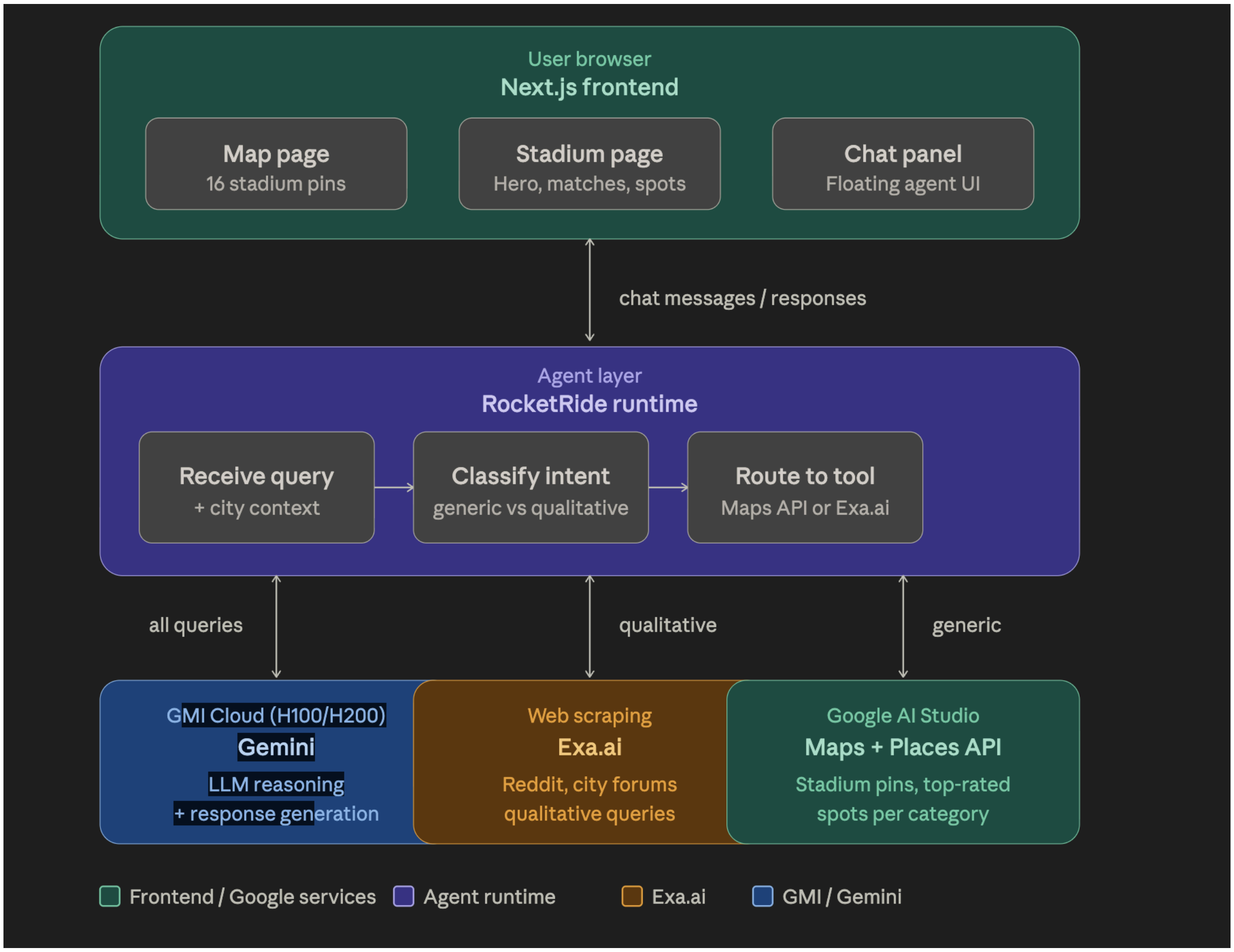
1. 1. User opens the app — sees a full-screen Google Map of North America with 16 labeled stadium pins
2. 2. User taps a pin (e.g. MetLife Stadium, New Jersey) — a tooltip shows stadium name + number of matches, with a 'Explore' button
3. 3. User taps Explore — navigates to /stadium/metlife — hero banner fills the screen with a stadium photo, name, and city
4. 4. Scrolling down reveals the match schedule (cards per game) and a brief city intro paragraph
5. 5. The Spots section loads with Food selected by default — 5 place cards with name, rating, and a Google Maps link
6. 6. User switches to Coffee — new cards load instantly (pre-fetched on page load)
7. 7. User opens the chat panel (floating button, bottom right) — types 'where should I go after the match that isn't too touristy?'
8. 8. Agent classifies as qualitative → triggers Exa.ai search of r/newjersey, r/AskNYC, r/worldcup → returns a specific recommendation with a source link to the Reddit thread
9. 9. User taps the back arrow — returns to the map to explore the next city

Teams & Data Flow

Tech Stack

Layer	Tool / Service
Frontend	Next.js (React) — fast page routing between map and stadium pages, server-side rendering for SEO
Map	Google Maps JavaScript API — renders the interactive stadium pin map
Place data	Google Maps Places API — fetches the 5 top-rated spots per category (Food, Coffee, etc.) for each city
AI model	Google AI Studio (Gemini) — powers the chat agent's reasoning and response generation
Inference	GMI Cloud (NVIDIA H100/H200) — runs model inference at scale using OpenAI-compatible API
Agent runtime	RocketRide — orchestrates the agent: routes queries, calls tools (Maps API or Exa), returns results
Web search	Exa.ai — semantic web scraper used to pull Reddit threads and city-specific forum posts for qualitative queries
Styling	Tailwind CSS — utility-first styling for rapid UI development during the hackathon
Deployment	Vercel — zero-config deploy for Next.js, instant preview URLs for demo
Key Technologies	Google AI Studio, GMI Cloud, RocketRide, Maps API, Exa.ai, Next.js

Architecture Overview



Design Choices

- **Map as the homepage:** Stadium-first navigation. Leading with a map makes the geographic scope of the World Cup visually exciting and immediately communicates the scale of the event.
- **No AI for the sidebar:** Pre-populated spots sidebar. The sidebar uses real Google Maps data, not AI-generated suggestions, ensuring the information is accurate, fast, and reliable. AI is reserved for the conversational layer where nuance matters.

- **City context passed automatically:** Context-aware chat agent. The agent always knows which stadium page the user is on. This means users can ask short, natural questions like 'any good izakayas nearby?' without typing the city name. This is a small detail that makes the product feel smart.
- **Reddit as local knowledge:** Exa.ai for qualitative queries. The insight here is that Reddit is one of the best sources of authentic, local recommendations on the internet. Exa's semantic search can pull the most relevant threads from city subreddits, which surfaces a different (and often better) kind of answer than a star rating ever could.
- **What we are NOT building:** Two-person scope discipline. No user accounts, no saved trips, no push notifications, no itinerary builder. The MVP is a read-only + chat experience. Keeping scope tight is what allows a team of two to ship something polished in one day.

Work Delegation/Team Split

Split cleanly across two tracks: frontend/UX and backend/AI. Both tracks are independently deployable so you are never blocked waiting on each other. The goal is to have something demoable by 3pm and polished by 5pm.

Task	Owner	Time Block
Set up Next.js project + Vercel deploy + shared GitHub repo	You	9:00 – 10:00 AM (before talks end)
Google Maps API integration — render map with all 16 stadium pins	You	11:30 AM – 1:00 PM
Stadium page routing — clicking a pin navigates to /stadium/[id]	You	11:30 AM – 1:00 PM
Stadium hero banner + match schedule UI (hardcoded data is fine)	You	1:00 – 2:30 PM
Spots sidebar — 5 category tabs with Google Maps Places API results	You	2:30 – 4:00 PM

Task	Owner	Time Block
Polish, transitions, mobile responsiveness	You	4:00 – 5:00 PM
RocketRide agent setup — install, configure, define tools	Sasha	11:30 AM – 1:00 PM
GMI Cloud account + API key setup, test Gemini model endpoint	Sasha	11:30 AM – 1:00 PM
Tool 1: Google Maps Places search function (for generic queries)	Sasha	1:00 – 2:00 PM
Tool 2: Exa.ai Reddit scraper function (for specific/qualitative queries)	Sasha	2:00 – 3:00 PM
Agent routing logic — decide when to use Maps vs Exa based on query intent	Sasha	3:00 – 3:45 PM
Connect agent to frontend chat UI (You builds the UI shell, Sasha wires the API)	Sasha	3:45 – 4:30 PM
End-to-end test: full user flow map → stadium → chat → response	Both	4:30 – 5:00 PM

Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
API key failure or credit limit	Display clear error; have backup keys
Auth misconfiguration at demo	Test in Hour 1; implement local bypass
Vercel deploy breaks last minute	Deploy "Hello World" in Hour 1; deploy after every change
Slow streaming during demo	Pre-record a backup video of the flow

Stretch Goals (if time allows)

- Multi-city trip planner — user selects 2+ stadiums and the agent builds a suggested travel route between them
- Real-time Reddit monitoring — surface threads posted during the tournament for live fan discussion
- Language toggle — translate all city content and agent responses into Spanish or Portuguese for international fans
- Match day alerts — notify the user when a game at their saved stadium is about to start
- 'Fan zone' tab in the sidebar — show official FIFA fan zones and events near each stadium

Demo Script (3 minutes)

Structure the 3-minute demo in three beats:

1. **0:00 – 0:40 | The problem.** '50 million fans are traveling to the US for the World Cup. Where do they go first? Google. Then Reddit. Then TripAdvisor. Then they give up and go to the hotel restaurant. We built one app that does all of that.'
2. **0:40 – 1:40 | The map.** Open the app — show the full map. Tap MetLife Stadium. Walk through the stadium page: hero banner, match schedule, city overview, switch between Food and Nightlife tabs in the sidebar.
3. **1:40 – 2:40 | The agent.** Open the chat. Ask: 'Where should I get coffee the morning of the match that isn't Starbucks?' Show the Exa-powered Reddit response with a source link. Then ask a generic query to show the Maps API path.
4. **2:40 – 3:00 | The close.** 'This is what every international fan needs: a single app that knows your stadium, your city, and can answer any question with real local knowledge — not just star ratings.'

Built in one day. Shipped for the World Cup. ⚽